PRECOMPOSITION ON CONTINUOUS ALTERNATING MAPS IS NOT ANALYTIC IN CHARACTERISTIC 2

JACK MCCARTHY

September 2026

Abstract. For normed spaces E, E', F over a nontrivially normed field k and a finite ι, precomposition $f \mapsto (m \mapsto m \circ (f, \dots, f))$ sends continuous linear maps $E \to E'$ to continuous linear maps between spaces of continuous alternating maps. It is C^n for every $n \in \mathbb{N} \cup \{\infty\}$ in every characteristic [12], and analytic when $|\iota|!$ is invertible in k (by polarisation). We show that it is *not* analytic in general: over every complete ultrametric field of characteristic 2 that is not spherically complete, with $E = E' = \ell^\infty$ and $|\iota| = 2$, analyticity fails at 0. The proof is a finite parity identity for determinants in characteristic 2, glued along ℓ^∞; the failure is witnessed by two coordinate projections of ℓ^∞. The result is formalized in Lean 4/Mathlib in the form "the general C^ω statement implies `False`".

1. Introduction

Let k be a nontrivially normed field. For normed spaces E, E', F over k and a finite ι we write $\mathcal{L}(E, E')$ for the space of continuous linear maps with the operator norm, and $\mathrm{Alt}^\iota(E, F)$ for the normed space of continuous alternating ι-linear maps $E^\iota \to F$; we write Alt^2 when $|\iota| = 2$.

Analytic functors. A map $f\colon X \to Z$ between normed spaces over k is **analytic at** $x_0 \in X$ if there are bounded n-linear maps $p_n\colon X^n \to Z$ and a radius $r > 0$ with $\sup_n \|p_n\| r^n < \infty$ such that $f(x_0 + h) = \sum_{n \geq 0} p_n(h, \dots, h)$ whenever $\|h\| < r$. It is **analytic**, or C^ω, if it is analytic at every point of X; this is the definition used in Mathlib [11].

Lang [10, Ch. III, §4] calls a functor T on Banach spaces **of class C^p** if $f \mapsto T(f)$ is C^p. Similarly, we call a contravariant endofunctor T on the category of normed spaces over k **analytic** if for all E, E' the map

$$\mathcal{L}(E, E') \to \mathcal{L}\big(T(E'), T(E)\big), \qquad f \mapsto T(f),$$

is analytic. For a normed space F and a finite ι, the assignment $E \mapsto \mathrm{Alt}^\iota(E, F)$, $f \mapsto (m \mapsto m \circ (f, \dots, f))$, is a contravariant functor. The assignment is also functorial in F: a continuous linear map $g\colon F \to F'$ acts by $m \mapsto g \circ m$. This action is linear in g, hence analytic, whereas the action of f is not linear in f. So the bifunctor Alt^ι is analytic if and only if the functor $\mathrm{Alt}^\iota(-, F)$ is analytic for every F.

Motivation: alternating bundles in Mathlib. In Mathlib, manifolds and vector bundles are modelled on normed spaces (of possibly infinite dimension) over an arbitrary nontrivially normed field k, and their regularity is an element $n \in \mathbb{N} \cup \{\infty, \omega\}$, where C^ω means analytic. Differential forms require the bundle of continuous alternating maps between two C^n vector bundles to be a C^n vector bundle again (an instance of `ContMDiffVectorBundle`). Its transition functions are those of the given bundles with Alt^ι applied, so this comes down to the regularity of the functor $\mathrm{Alt}^\iota(-, F)$, i.e. of the precomposition map

`ContinuousAlternatingMap.compContinuousLinearMapCLM`.

Two cases have been settled, in pull requests to Mathlib.

- If $|\iota|!$ is invertible in k then $\mathrm{Alt}^\iota(-,F)$ is analytic, by polarisation. In Mathlib this is done in characteristic 0 by Gouëzel [6], who uses it to construct the bundle for every n in characteristic 0 [7]; he remarks that a variant of the argument, not included there, covers finite-dimensional spaces in positive characteristic, but not the general case.
- Over every k, with no hypothesis on the characteristic or the dimension, $\mathrm{Alt}^\iota(-,F)$ is of class C^n for every $n \in \mathbb{N} \cup \{\infty\}$ [12].

This leaves open the case where $|\iota|!$ is not invertible in k and the spaces are infinite-dimensional: is $\mathrm{Alt}^\iota(-,F)$ analytic there? The following theorem provides a counterexample.

Theorem 1. *Let k be a complete ultrametric field of characteristic 2 which is not spherically complete. There is a Banach space F over k such that the functor $\mathrm{Alt}^2(-,F)$ is not analytic.*

Thus the restriction $n \neq \omega$ in [12] cannot be removed. In characteristic $\ell \geq 3$ the case $|\iota| \geq \ell$ remains open (Remark 17). The result is machine-checked in Lean 4 with Mathlib (§10).

2. Statement

Notation. For a polynomial f and a monomial μ, $\mathrm{coeff}_\mu f$ is the coefficient of μ in f. We write $c_0 \subset \ell^\infty$ for the null sequences, $\mathbf{1}_S$ for the indicator of a set S, and $\mathbf{1} = \mathbf{1}_{\mathbb{N}}$.

Throughout, k is a field which is complete for a nontrivial absolute value $|\cdot|$ satisfying the **ultrametric inequality** $|x+y| \leq \max(|x|,|y|)$; we call such a field **ultrametric**. The sup norms used below inherit the inequality. We assume that

(K1) $\mathrm{char}\, k = 2$;

(K2) k is not spherically complete: there is a sequence of closed balls $B(c_n, r_n)$ such that $|c_{n+1} - c_n| \leq r_n$, $r_0 > r_1 > \cdots$ and $\bigcap_n B(c_n, r_n) = \emptyset$.

The balls in (K2) are balls in k, and they are nested by the ultrametric inequality. Such fields exist; an explicit one is given in §7. Let $E = \ell^\infty = \ell^\infty(\mathbb{N}, k)$ with the sup norm, a Banach algebra under pointwise multiplication; write $m_a \in \mathcal{L}(E,E)$ for multiplication by $a \in E$, so that $\|m_a\| = \|a\|$, and e_i for the unit vectors. For $x, y \in E$ let

$$W(x,y) := x \otimes y + y \otimes x \in \ell^\infty(\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}, k), \qquad W(x,y)_{pq} = x_p y_q + x_q y_p,$$

and let $F \subseteq \ell^\infty(\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}, k)$ be the closed linear span of all $W(x,y)$, a Banach space. Let

$$Q \colon \mathcal{L}(E,E) \to \mathcal{L}\big(\mathrm{Alt}^2(E,F), \mathrm{Alt}^2(E,F)\big), \qquad Q(f)(m) = m \circ (f,f).$$

Theorem 2. *Q is not analytic at 0. In particular Q is not C^ω.*

The map Q is the action on $\mathcal{L}(E,E)$ of the functor $\mathrm{Alt}^2(-,F)$, so Theorem 2 implies Theorem 1. Sections 3–6 prove Theorem 2 in four steps.

3. Step 1: analyticity forces a bilinear lift

Recall that $Q \colon \mathcal{L}(E,E) \to \mathcal{L}(\mathrm{Alt}^2(E,F), \mathrm{Alt}^2(E,F))$ is given by $Q(f)(m) = m \circ (f,f)$, so that $Q(tf) = t^2 Q(f)$. Steps 1 and 2 do not use (K2): until Step 3, k may be any ultrametric field of characteristic 2.

Lemma 3. *Let $Q \colon X \to Z$ be a map between normed spaces with $Q(tf) = t^2 Q(f)$. If Q is analytic at 0 then there is a bounded bilinear $P \colon X \times X \to Z$ with $P(f,f) = Q(f)$ for all f.*

Proof. Let $\sum_n p_n$ be a power series of Q at 0, and fix $f \in X$. For scalars $t \in k$ with $|t|$ small,

$$t^2 Q(f) = Q(tf) = \sum_n t^n \, p_n(f, \ldots, f).$$

Both sides are power series in the variable $t \in k$ with coefficients in Z. The coefficients of a convergent power series in one variable are unique over any nontrivially normed field, so comparing the coefficients of t^2 gives $p_2(f,f) = Q(f)$. Take $P = p_2$. □

So assume that a bounded bilinear P with $P(f,f) = Q(f)$ exists. The map $W\colon E \times E \to F$ is bilinear, it is alternating because $W(x,x) = 2\,x \otimes x = 0$, and it is continuous because $\|W(x,y)\| \le \|x\|\|y\|$ by the ultrametric inequality; so $W \in \mathrm{Alt}^2(E,F)$ with $\|W\| \le 1$. Put, for $a,b,x,y \in E$,

$$\Phi(a,b;x,y) := P(m_a, m_b)(W)(x,y) \in F.$$

Then Φ is 4-linear, and since $\|m_a\| = \|a\|$ and $\|W\| \le 1$ we have

$$\|\Phi(a,b;x,y)\| \le C\|a\|\,\|b\|\,\|x\|\,\|y\|, \qquad C := \|P\|.$$

Here $C \ge 1$, because $P(\mathrm{id},\mathrm{id}) = Q(\mathrm{id})$ is the identity map of $\mathrm{Alt}^2(E,F) \neq 0$. Moreover

$$\Phi(a,b;x,x) = 0, \qquad \Phi(a,a;x,y) = W(ax,ay). \tag{1}$$

Since $2 = 0$, the first identity gives the symmetry $\Phi(a,b;x,y) = \Phi(a,b;y,x)$. We will contradict the existence of such a Φ.

4. Step 2: a finite parity identity

Fix a finite set $I \subset \mathbb{N}$ of even size $2m$ and $a', b' \in E$ with $\|a'\|, \|b'\| \le 1$. Let X_i, Y_i $(i \in I)$ be indeterminates. Expanding Φ multilinearly in $x = \sum_{i\in I} X_i e_i$ and $y = \sum_{i\in I} Y_i e_i$ defines, for any fixed $p,q \in I$, a polynomial

$$G_{pq} := \Phi(a' + x,\, b' + y;\, a' + x,\, b' + y)_{pq} \in k[X_i, Y_i]_{i\in I}$$

in the polynomial ring in these $4m$ variables, which we abbreviate to $k[X,Y]$. The values of the G_{pq} at points $x, y \in k^I$ (vectors supported on I) are the entries of an $I \times I$ matrix $G(x,y)$. We also put

$$g_{pq} := \Phi(x,y;x,y)_{pq} = \sum_{i,j,k,l\in I} \Phi(e_i,e_j;e_k,e_l)_{pq}\, X_iY_jX_kY_l \in k[X,Y].$$

Proposition 4. *The matrix $G = (G_{pq})_{p,q\in I}$ is symmetric with zero diagonal: $G_{pq} = G_{qp}$ and $G_{pp} = 0$ in $k[X,Y]$.*

Proof. Every element of F is a symmetric matrix with zero diagonal, since $W(x,y)_{pq} = W(x,y)_{qp}$ and $W(x,y)_{pp} = 2x_py_p = 0$, and both properties pass to the closed span. The coefficients of G_{pq} are the (p,q) entries of values of Φ, which lie in F. □

Proposition 5. *The polynomial g_{pq} is homogeneous of degree 2 in the X_i and of degree 2 in the Y_i, and $G_{pq} - g_{pq}$ has total degree ≤ 3. In particular G_{pq} has total degree ≤ 4.*

Proof. By 4-linearity, G_{pq} is a sum of 16 terms, according to whether each of the four slots is filled by the constant vector (a' or b') or by the variable one (x or y), and the total degree of a term is the number of its variable slots. So g_{pq}, which has two slots with x and two with y, is exactly the degree 4 part of G_{pq}, and $G_{pq} - g_{pq}$ has total degree ≤ 3. □

Proposition 6. *For $p \neq q$ we have, in $k[X,Y]$,*

$$g_{pq}(Y,X) = g_{pq}(X,Y) + X_p^2Y_q^2 + X_q^2Y_p^2 \qquad \textit{and} \qquad g_{pq}(X,X) = 0.$$

Proof. The field k is infinite, since it has a nontrivial absolute value, and a polynomial over an infinite field which vanishes at every point is zero. So it suffices to check these identities at points $x, y \in k^I$. By the symmetry in the last two slots, $g(y,x) = \Phi(y,x;y,x) = \Phi(y,x;x,y)$, so by bilinearity in the first two slots and (1)

$$\begin{aligned} g(x,y) + g(y,x) &= \Phi(x+y, x+y; x, y) + \Phi(x,x;x,y) + \Phi(y,y;x,y) \\ &= W\big((x+y)x, (x+y)y\big) + W(x^2, xy) + W(xy, y^2) \\ &= \big[W(x^2,xy) + W(x^2,y^2) + W(xy,xy) + W(xy,y^2)\big] \\ &\quad + W(x^2,xy) + W(xy,y^2) \\ &= W(x^2, y^2), \end{aligned}$$

where the last step uses $2 = 0$ and $W(xy,xy) = 0$. This is the matrix whose (p,q) entry is $x_p^2 y_q^2 + x_q^2 y_p^2$. Finally $g(x,x) = W(x^2,x^2) = 0$. □

Let τ be the automorphism of $k[X,Y]$ swapping $X_i \leftrightarrow Y_i$, and δ the substitution $Y_i := X_i$.

Lemma 7 (balanced coefficients)**.** *Let $f \in k[X,Y]$ with $\tau f = f$. For every $S \subseteq I$ the coefficient of $\prod_{i\in S} X_i Y_i$ in f equals the coefficient of $\prod_{i\in S} X_i^2$ in δf.*

Proof. The coefficient of $\prod_S X_i^2$ in δf is the sum of the coefficients in f of all monomials $X^\alpha Y^\beta$ with $\alpha + \beta = 2 \cdot \mathbf{1}_S$. The involution $(\alpha, \beta) \mapsto (\beta, \alpha)$ of this set of monomials preserves coefficients (as $\tau f = f$), and its only fixed point is $\alpha = \beta = \mathbf{1}_S$; all other terms cancel in pairs. Thus the coefficient of $\prod_S X_i^2$ in δf is equal to the coefficient of $X^{\mathbf{1}_S} Y^{\mathbf{1}_S} = \prod_{i\in S} X_i Y_i$ in f. □

A **perfect matching** of I is a partition of I into m unordered pairs $\{p,q\}$, its edges; for example $\{1,2,3,4\}$ has the three perfect matchings $12|34$, $13|24$ and $14|23$. Since $G_{pq} = G_{qp}$ (Proposition 4), the product of the G_{pq} over the edges of a perfect matching is well defined.

Proposition 8. *Let M be a perfect matching of I and $\nu := \prod_{i\in I} X_i Y_i$. Then*

$$\operatorname{coeff}_\nu \prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} G_{pq} = 1.$$

Proof. Write $G_{pq} = g_{pq} + c_{pq}$, where g_{pq} is homogeneous of total degree 4 and c_{pq} has total degree ≤ 3 (Proposition 5). Expanding the product over the m edges of M gives $\prod_M g_{pq}$ plus terms that contain at least one factor c_{pq}, and each such term has total degree $\le 3 + 4(m-1) = 4m-1$. The monomial ν has total degree $4m$, so only $\prod_M g_{pq}$ contributes to its coefficient:

$$\operatorname{coeff}_\nu \prod_M G_{pq} = \operatorname{coeff}_\nu \prod_M g_{pq}.$$

Put $g'_{pq} := g_{pq} + X_p^2 Y_q^2$. By Proposition 6,

$$\tau g'_{pq} = g'_{pq} \qquad \text{and} \qquad \delta g'_{pq} = X_p^2 X_q^2.$$

A product containing a factor $X_p^2 Y_q^2$ has no squarefree monomial, so replacing every g_{pq} by g'_{pq} does not change the coefficient of ν. By Lemma 7, applied to the τ-invariant product $\prod_M g'_{pq}$, this coefficient is the coefficient of $\prod_{i\in I} X_i^2$ in

$$\delta \prod_M g'_{pq} = \prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} X_p^2 X_q^2 = \prod_{i\in I} X_i^2,$$

which is exactly 1. □

Lemma 9. *Let A be a symmetric matrix with zero diagonal over a commutative ring of characteristic 2, of even size $2m$. Then $\det A = \sum_M \prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} A_{pq}^2$, the sum being over perfect matchings; and the number of perfect matchings is $(2m-1)!!$.*

Proof. In characteristic 2 we have $\det A = \sum_\sigma \prod_i A_{i\sigma(i)}$. As A is symmetric, σ and σ^{-1} give the same product, so the permutations with $\sigma \neq \sigma^{-1}$ cancel in pairs and only the involutions remain. An involution with a fixed point i contributes the factor $A_{ii} = 0$. An involution without fixed points is a product of m disjoint transpositions $(p\ q)$; the pairs $\{p,q\}$ form a perfect matching M, every perfect matching arises exactly once in this way, and therefore

$$\det A = \sum_M \prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} A_{pq}A_{qp} = \sum_M \prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} A_{pq}^2.$$

Finally, pairing the smallest index with one of the $2m-1$ others and continuing with the remaining indices shows that there are $(2m-1)(2m-3)\cdots 3\cdot 1 = (2m-1)!!$ perfect matchings. □

Lemma 10 (hypercube sum)**.** *Let R be a commutative ring of characteristic 2 and let $f \in R[Z_1,\dots,Z_N]$ have total degree $\le N$. Then $\sum_{z\in\{0,1\}^N} f(z)$ is the coefficient of $Z_1Z_2\cdots Z_N$ in f.*

Proof. By linearity we may take f to be a monomial Z^α. At a point $z \in \{0,1\}^N$ it takes the value 1 if $z_i = 1$ for all i in the support of α, and 0 otherwise; so the sum is $2^{N-|\operatorname{supp}\alpha|}$, which vanishes in R unless every variable occurs in Z^α. The only monomial of degree $\le N$ in which all N variables occur is $Z_1\cdots Z_N$. □

Corollary 11. *We have*

$$\sum_{x,y\in\{0,1\}^I} \det G(x,y) = 1,$$

and consequently there are $x, y \in \{0,1\}^I$ with $|\det G(x,y)| \ge 1$.

Proof. Each G_{pq} has total degree ≤ 4 (Proposition 5), so for a perfect matching M the product $\prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} G_{pq}$ has total degree $\le 4m$. By Lemma 10 with $N = 4m$, the number of variables of $k[X,Y]$, and by Proposition 8,

$$\sum_{x,y\in\{0,1\}^I} \prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} G_{pq}(x,y) = \operatorname{coeff}_\nu \prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} G_{pq} = 1, \qquad \text{where } \nu = \prod_{i\in I} X_iY_i.$$

For each pair x, y the matrix $G(x,y)$ is symmetric with zero diagonal (Proposition 4), so Lemma 9 applies to it. In characteristic 2 we have the Frobenius endomorphism $a \mapsto a^2$ of k. Hence

$$\begin{aligned}\sum_{x,y\in\{0,1\}^I} \det G(x,y) &= \sum_{x,y\in\{0,1\}^I} \sum_M \prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} G_{pq}(x,y)^2 \\ &= \sum_M \Big(\sum_{x,y\in\{0,1\}^I} \prod_{\{p,q\}\in M} G_{pq}(x,y)\Big)^2 = \sum_M 1^2 = (2m-1)!! = 1,\end{aligned}$$

because $(2m-1)!!$ is odd. By the ultrametric inequality, $1 \le \max_{x,y\in\{0,1\}^I} |\det G(x,y)|$. □

5. Step 3: locality on ℓ^∞

This step uses (K2) and the completeness of k, which are standing hypotheses of §2, but not the characteristic. Recall (K2): there are centres $c_n \in k$ and radii $r_0 > r_1 > \cdots > 0$ with $|c_{n+1}-c_n| \le r_n$ such that no element of k lies in all the balls $B(c_n, r_n) = \{a \in k : |a-c_n| \le r_n\}$. Recall also that $e_i \in \ell^\infty$ are the unit vectors. For $x \in \ell^\infty$ write $x|_{\ge N}$ for x with its coordinates below N set to 0.

Proposition 12. *A bounded linear functional φ on ℓ^∞ with $\varphi(e_i) = 0$ for all i is zero.*

Proof. Suppose $\varphi \neq 0$. Since $r_{n+1} < r_n$ we have $\|\varphi\|\, r_{n+1}/r_n < \|\varphi\|$, so by the definition of the operator norm there is $u_n \in \ell^\infty$ with $|\varphi(u_n)| > \|\varphi\|\,(r_{n+1}/r_n)\,\|u_n\|$. Put $s_n := (c_{n+2} - c_{n+1})\, u_n/\varphi(u_n)$. Then

$$\varphi(s_n) = c_{n+2} - c_{n+1} \qquad \text{and} \qquad \|s_n\| = |c_{n+2} - c_{n+1}|\,\frac{\|u_n\|}{|\varphi(u_n)|} \le r_{n+1} \cdot \frac{r_n}{r_{n+1}\|\varphi\|} = \frac{r_n}{\|\varphi\|}.$$

The difference $s_n - s_n|_{\ge n}$ is finitely supported, so by linearity $\varphi(s_n - s_n|_{\ge n}) = 0$; hence $\varphi(s_n|_{\ge n}) = c_{n+2} - c_{n+1}$. Moreover $\|s_n|_{\ge n}\| \le \|s_n\| \le r_n/\|\varphi\|$. Define $y := \sum_k s_k|_{\ge k}$ coordinatewise; the sum is finite in every coordinate i because $s_k|_{\ge k}$ vanishes at i when $k > i$. By the ultrametric inequality $\|y\| \le \max_k \|s_k\| \le r_0/\|\varphi\|$, so $y \in \ell^\infty$, and likewise $\|y - \sum_{k<n} s_k|_{\ge k}\| \le \max_{k\ge n}\|s_k\| \le r_n/\|\varphi\|$. Hence, using the telescoping sum $\sum_{k<n} \varphi(s_k|_{\ge k}) = c_{n+1} - c_1$,

$$|\varphi(y) + c_1 - c_{n+1}| = \Big|\varphi\Big(y - \sum_{k<n} s_k|_{\ge k}\Big)\Big| \le \|\varphi\| \,\Big\|y - \sum_{k<n} s_k|_{\ge k}\Big\| \le \|\varphi\| \cdot \frac{r_n}{\|\varphi\|} = r_n.$$

Put $a := \varphi(y) + c_1 \in k$. We have just shown that $|a - c_{n+1}| \le r_n$, and $|c_{n+1} - c_n| \le r_n$ by (K2), so by the ultrametric inequality $|a - c_n| \le \max\big(|a - c_{n+1}|, |c_{n+1} - c_n|\big) \le r_n$ for every n. Thus $a \in \bigcap_n B(c_n, r_n)$, which contradicts (K2). □

This is the direction of van der Put's theorem [16] that we need, $(\ell^\infty/c_0)' = 0$; the index shift absorbs the usual $(1+\varepsilon)$ loss, and no Hahn–Banach argument is used.

Proposition 13 (multilinear Phillips property)**.** *Let λ be a bounded d-linear form on ℓ^∞ and $\varepsilon > 0$. There is N such that $|\lambda(u_1, \dots, u_d)| \le \varepsilon$ whenever $\|u_j\| \le 1$ for all j and $u_j = u_j|_{\ge N}$ for some j.*

Sketch (the complete proof is in the Lean development). *The case $d = 1$, $\lambda = \varphi$.* (a) $\varphi(e_i) \to 0$. Otherwise $|\varphi(e_{i_k})| \ge \varepsilon$ along a subsequence. Let T be the bounded operator with $T(x)_{i_k} = x_k/\varphi(e_{i_k})$ and all other coordinates 0, and $\psi := \varphi \circ T$, so that $\psi(e_k) = 1$ for all k. With sh the right shift, $\psi \circ (1 - \mathrm{sh})$ kills every e_k, hence vanishes by Proposition 12; but $(1 - \mathrm{sh})\mathbf{1} = e_0$, so $0 = \psi(e_0) = 1$. (b) For fixed x, $\varphi(x|_{\ge N}) - \varphi(x|_{\ge N+1}) = x_N \varphi(e_N) \to 0$, so $\varphi(x|_{\ge N})$ converges, as k is complete; the limit is a bounded linear functional of x killing every e_i, hence it is 0. (c) If the claim failed for ε, then (b) would give unit vectors w_k with disjoint finite supports moving to infinity and $|\varphi(w_k)| > \varepsilon$; the functional $c \mapsto \varphi(\sum_k c_k w_k)$ (coordinatewise sum) then contradicts (a).

The case $d > 1$, by induction on d. Suppose the claim fails for ε. First, for every M there is a unit tuple with $|\lambda| > \varepsilon$ *all* of whose slots vanish below M: start from a witness one of whose slots is supported very far out, and split any other slot into its part below M, a finite combination of the e_i, and its tail; the inductive hypothesis, applied to the finitely many $(d-1)$-linear forms obtained by freezing that slot at e_i, $i < M$, shows that the part below M contributes at most ε, so the tail carries $|\lambda| > \varepsilon$. Next, by (b) each slot can be cut down to a finite window. Finally choose such tuples $z^{(s)}$ with windows moving to infinity fast enough and let x be the coordinatewise sum of their first slots. Then $\lambda(x, z_2^{(s)}, \dots, z_d^{(s)})$ equals $\lambda(z^{(s)})$, plus

finitely many terms with an earlier first slot (each $\le \varepsilon$ by the inductive hypothesis for $\lambda(z_1^{(r)}, \cdot)$, $r < s$), plus one term with a far first slot ($\le \varepsilon$ by the case $d = 1$). So it has absolute value $> \varepsilon$ for every s, contradicting the inductive hypothesis for the $(d-1)$-linear form $\lambda(x, \cdot)$. □

This is exactly where ℓ^∞ and (K2) are used; the statement is false for c_0 and for spherically complete fields.

6. Step 4: gluing

Recall from Step 1 that Φ is 4-linear with values in F and that

$$\|\Phi(a, b; x, y)\| \le C\|a\|\,\|b\|\,\|x\|\,\|y\| \qquad \text{with } C \ge 1.$$

We now combine Corollary 11 (Step 2) with Proposition 13 (Step 3); apart from these, only the ultrametric inequality is used.

Choose inductively finite sets $I_1 < I_2 < \cdots$ in $\mathbb{N}$ (every element of I_t is smaller than every element of I_{t+1}) with $|I_t| = 2t$ and vectors $a_t, b_t \in \{0,1\}^{I_t}$ as follows. Given the earlier stages let $a' = \sum_{s<t} a_s$, $b' = \sum_{s<t} b_s$, and apply Corollary 11 to get a_t, b_t with $|\det G_t| \ge 1$, where $G_t = \Phi(a' + a_t, b' + b_t; a' + a_t, b' + b_t)|_{I_t \times I_t}$. Put $\varepsilon_t := \frac{1}{2}C^{-2t}$ and use Proposition 13 (with $d = 4$) for the finitely many entry forms $\Phi(\cdot)_{pq}$, $p, q \in I_t$, to place all later sets I_s, $s > t$, so far out that these forms are at most ε_t on unit arguments one of which is supported there.

Let $a, b \in \ell^\infty$ be defined by $a|_{I_t} = a_t$, $b|_{I_t} = b_t$ and zero elsewhere. These are not norm-convergent sums; $a = \mathbf{1}_A$ and $b = \mathbf{1}_B$ are indicator functions of two subsets of $\mathbb{N}$, so m_a, m_b are coordinate projections. Let $\mathcal{O} := \Phi(a, b; a, b) \in F$. Splitting $a = a^{\le t} + a^{>t}$, $b = b^{\le t} + b^{>t}$ and using multilinearity, $\|\mathcal{O}|_{I_t \times I_t} - G_t\| \le \varepsilon_t$. All entries are bounded by C. Expanding the determinant multilinearly in columns, every term containing a column of the perturbation is at most $\varepsilon_t C^{2t-1} < 1$, so the ultrametric inequality gives

$$|\det \mathcal{O}|_{I_t \times I_t}| = |\det G_t| \ge 1 \qquad \text{for every } t.$$

On the other hand, every element of F is a uniform limit of matrices of finite rank, because each $W(x, y)$ has rank ≤ 2. So $\mathcal{O} \in F$ is within $\eta := (2C)^{-1}$ of a matrix R of some finite rank r. Expanding $\det(R + (\mathcal{O} - R))$ on $I_t \times I_t$ in the same way, terms with more than r columns from R vanish, so $|\det \mathcal{O}|_{I_t \times I_t}| \le C^r \eta^{2t-r} < 1$ once $t > r$. This contradiction proves Theorem 2. □

7. An explicit field

The purpose of this section is to construct a field satisfying (K1) and (K2). Towards that end, let $k_0 = \mathbb{F}_2$ (or any field of characteristic 2). For $j \ge 0$ let $k_0((t^{1/2^j}))$ be the field of *formal* Laurent series $\sum_{n \ge N} a_n t^{n/2^j}$ ($N \in \mathbb{Z}$, $a_n \in k_0$) in the single variable $t^{1/2^j}$. These fields form an increasing chain, and we let

$$\mathcal{P} := \bigcup_{j \ge 0} k_0((t^{1/2^j})), \qquad |f| := 2^{-\operatorname{ord} f},$$

be the field of **2-power Puiseux series**. Here $\operatorname{ord} f$ is the minimum q for which $\operatorname{coeff}_{t^q} f \ne 0$. We set $|0| = 0$ by definition. Let k be the completion of $\mathcal{P}$ for this (ultrametric) absolute value. This is characteristic 2 since $k_0 \hookrightarrow \mathcal{P} \hookrightarrow k$.

Proposition 14. *k is not spherically complete.*

Proof. We exhibit a sequence of balls as in (K2). Put

$$\gamma_m := 1 - 2^{-(m+1)}, \qquad c_n := \sum_{m=0}^{n} t^{\gamma_m} \in \mathcal{P}, \qquad r_n := 2^{-\gamma_{n+1}}.$$

The balls have the form required in (K2). Since $c_{n+1} - c_n = t^{\gamma_{n+1}}$ we have $|c_{n+1} - c_n| = 2^{-\gamma_{n+1}} = r_n$. Since the γ_m are strictly increasing to 1, the r_n are strictly decreasing, and $r_n > 2^{-1} = \frac{1}{2}$.

The intersection is empty. Suppose that $a \in k$ satisfies $|a - c_n| \le r_n$ for all n. As $\mathcal{P}$ is dense in k there is $y \in \mathcal{P}$ with $|a - y| < \frac{1}{2}$, and then for every n

$$|y - c_n| \le \max\big(|y - a|, |a - c_n|\big) \le \max\big(\tfrac{1}{2}, r_n\big) = r_n. \tag{2}$$

Now $y \in k_0((t^{1/2^j}))$ for some j. The exponent $\gamma_j = (2^{j+1} - 1)/2^{j+1}$ has an odd numerator, therefore γ_j is not a multiple of $1/2^j$ and so $\operatorname{coeff}_{t^{\gamma_j}} y = 0$. For $n \ge j$ we have $2^{-\gamma_j} > 2^{-\gamma_{n+1}} = r_n$. Furthermore, the term t^{γ_j} occurs in c_n, so

$$\operatorname{coeff}_{t^{\gamma_j}}(y - c_n) = 0 - 1 \neq 0, \qquad \text{hence} \qquad \operatorname{ord}(y - c_n) \le \gamma_j \quad \text{and} \quad |y - c_n| \ge 2^{-\gamma_j} > r_n,$$

which contradicts (2). □

8. Remarks

Remark 15 (Why characteristic 2, why ℓ^∞, why this F). In characteristic $\neq 2$ the lift $\frac{1}{2}\big(m \circ (f, g) + m \circ (g, f)\big)$ exists, and the parity argument breaks (pairs add instead of cancelling). If E has an orthogonal base (e_i), e.g. $E = c_0$, and F is Banach, then

$$P(f, g)(m)(x, y) = \sum_{i<j} (x_i y_j - x_j y_i)\, m(f e_i, g e_j)$$

is a bounded lift in every characteristic, so Q is analytic; a similar formula works for a base of E', and t-orthogonal bases suffice. This covers finite-dimensional E and all Banach spaces over a discretely valued k [17], so the counterexample needs a dense valuation; one can also show that Q is analytic when F is spherically complete. On c_0 the glued vectors a, b of Step 4 do not exist and Proposition 13 fails. For $E = \ell^\infty$ and the larger target $\ell^\infty(\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}, k) \supsetneq F$ a bounded lift also exists (sort the indices entrywise), but it sends W to matrices such as the "staircase" $\mathbf{1}_{\{(p,q)\,:\,p \text{ odd}, q \text{ even}, p<q\}}$, which are not limits of finite-rank matrices, so it leaves F. These positive statements are not proved here and are not part of the formalization.

Remark 16 (What is forced). No single pair (x, y) works for every lift: adding to Φ a bounded 4-linear map with values in F that is alternating in (a, b) and in (x, y) gives another admissible Φ, and this can change a given off-diagonal entry of $G(x, y)$ by an arbitrary scalar. Sets I of bounded size cannot give a contradiction either: for $u = \mathbf{1}_{\text{odd}}$, $v = \mathbf{1}_{\text{even}}$ the rank-two matrix $W(u, v) \in F$ has the entry 1 at every position $(2s - 1, 2s)$. On a finite set I the sorted lift of the previous remark has norm 1 and satisfies all the identities of Step 2, so there is no finite-dimensional obstruction: the invariant is the rank of one element of F against the size of the sets I_t, and Step 3 is what allows infinitely many of them to be glued into one element.

Remark 17 (Higher degree, other characteristics). On paper, in characteristic 2 every $|\iota| \ge 2$ is covered by wedging with a coordinate of $E \oplus k$; this is not formalized. In odd characteristic ℓ, for forms of degree ℓ, the question is open: odd-degree forms have no Pfaffian-type top power, so a different invariant is needed.

9. Related work

What is known. The lifts of Step 1 are classical in algebra: a quadratic form Q on a finitely generated projective module is $x \mapsto \beta(x,x)$ for a bilinear form β, not necessarily symmetric and unique up to alternating forms [14, Lemma 1.12]. The proof there is the sorted lift of Remark 15. Over a field the statement is the exact sequence

$$0 \to \operatorname{Alt}(V) \to \operatorname{Bil}(V) \to \operatorname{Quad}(V) \to 0, \qquad \beta \mapsto \big(x \mapsto \beta(x,x)\big),$$

of alternating, bilinear and quadratic forms on a finite-dimensional vector space V [2, Ch. II]: surjectivity says that lifts exist, and exactness in the middle that they are unique up to alternating forms. In these terms the present note shows that the corresponding map from bounded bilinear maps to bounded quadratic maps on $\mathcal{L}(E,E)$ is not surjective. The name "bilinear lift" is used in [15, §3] for symmetric β over a field of characteristic 2; there the forms being lifted have vanishing polar form, existence is taken as known, and the question is uniqueness. The notion of this note appears under the name "expansion" in [9, Def. 5.1], with the sorted lift as its existence proof. Equivalently, Q is a linear map on the divided power Γ^2 ([13]; see [1]), which for a free module is the module of symmetric tensors, and a lift is an extension of this map to the whole tensor square; polynomial laws and divided powers are being formalized in Lean [1].

Lifts can fail to exist for algebraic reasons. For abelian groups, every quadratic form with values in every group has a lift if and only if the group has no 2-torsion [3, §5]. In characteristic 2 a nonzero invariant quadratic form on a nontrivial irreducible representation of a split reductive group G has no invariant lift, and the obstruction lies in $H^1(G, \Lambda^2 V)$ [4, §11]. In the second case, as in this note, a lift exists once the extra structure is forgotten; in the first it fails outright.

Over $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}$ polarisation makes the question vacuous. Glöckner [5] constructed finite-dimensional smooth Lie groups over local fields of positive characteristic that admit no compatible analytic Lie group structure, by a different mechanism. The failure of the Hahn–Banach theorem over fields that are not spherically complete goes back to Ingleton [8] and van der Put [16]; Proposition 12 is one direction of van der Put's theorem. Lemma 9 is the classical fact that the determinant of an alternating matrix is the square of its Pfaffian, and Lemma 10 is the computation in the standard proof of the Chevalley–Warning theorem.

What is new. We did not find the following in the literature; the search and its limits are recorded in the file `paper/LITERATURE.md` of the repository of §10.

- The question of *bounded* lifts between normed spaces, and an example in which none exists (Lemma 3 and Steps 2–4).
- The identity of Step 2 (Proposition 8 and Corollary 11), which holds for every 4-linear Φ satisfying (1).
- The multilinear form of the tail property (Proposition 13); for $d = 1$ it follows from van der Put's theorem.
- The consequence that $\operatorname{Alt}^\iota(-,F)$ is not analytic: the general case in positive characteristic, which [6] does not cover, has a negative answer in characteristic 2.

10. Formalization

The Lean 4/Mathlib development is at

https://github.com/Deicyde/alternating-analytic-counterexample

The library `AltCounter/` contains no `sorry`, and the only axioms it uses are the three standard ones (`propext`, `Quot.sound` and `Classical.choice`). Its headline theorem assumes that Mathlib's

`ContinuousAlternatingMap.compContinuousLinearMapCLM`

is C^ω for all nontrivially normed fields, normed spaces and finite index types, and derives `False`; a second theorem does the same assuming this only for complete ultrametric fields of characteristic 2, Banach spaces, $E' = E$ and $|\iota| = 2$. Both are restated in a Mathlib-only file `Challenge.lean` (with `sorry` in place of the proofs, as that format requires) and checked against `Solution.lean` by the `leanprover/comparator` tool. Steps 1–4 and §7 are formalized, including the complete proof of Proposition 13 by induction on d; Lemma 10 is `sum_eval_cubePt`, and the field of §7 is built with $k_0 = \mathbb{F}_2$. The Lean constants in Step 4 are chosen with more slack than here, and the Lean form of Corollary 11 records only that the witnesses lie in the unit ball, which is all that Step 4 uses. Not formalized: non-analyticity at base points other than 0, index types with more than two elements, the positive statements in the remarks, and the bundle-level consequence (no C^ω vector-bundle structure on bundles of continuous alternating maps in this generality).

References

[1] A. Chambert-Loir and M. I. de Frutos-Fernández, *Formalizing polynomial laws and the universal divided power algebra*, CPP '26, arXiv:2512.05750.

[2] R. Elman, N. Karpenko and A. Merkurjev, *The Algebraic and Geometric Theory of Quadratic Forms*, Amer. Math. Soc. Colloquium Publications 56, 2008.

[3] C. Galindo, *A note on the Eilenberg–Mac Lane isomorphism for quadratic forms*, arXiv:2507.15726, 2025.

[4] S. Garibaldi and D. K. Nakano, *Bilinear and quadratic forms on rational modules of split reductive groups*, Canad. J. Math. **68** (2016), 395–421.

[5] H. Glöckner, *Smooth Lie groups over local fields of positive characteristic need not be analytic*, J. Algebra **285** (2005), 356–371.

[6] S. Gouëzel, *In characteristic* 0*, precomposition by a linear map is analytic on the space of alternating maps*, pull request #43338 to Mathlib, https://github.com/leanprover-community/mathlib4/pull/43338.

[7] S. Gouëzel, *The bundle of continuous alternating maps is* C^n, draft pull request #43234 to Mathlib, https://github.com/leanprover-community/mathlib4/pull/43234.

[8] A. W. Ingleton, *The Hahn–Banach theorem for non-Archimedean-valued fields*, Proc. Cambridge Philos. Soc. **48** (1952), 41–45.

[9] Z. Izhakian, M. Knebusch and L. Rowen, *Quadratic and symmetric bilinear forms on modules with unique base over a semiring*, arXiv:1509.01039, 2015.

[10] S. Lang, *Fundamentals of Differential Geometry*, Graduate Texts in Mathematics 191, Springer, 1999.

[11] The mathlib Community, *Mathlib documentation*, `docs#AnalyticAt`, https://leanprover-community.github.io/mathlib4_docs/find/?pattern=AnalyticAt#doc.

[12] J. McCarthy, *Smoothness reflects along a linear isometry with closed range*, draft pull request #43548 to Mathlib, https://github.com/leanprover-community/mathlib4/pull/43548.

[13] N. Roby, *Lois polynômes et lois formelles en théorie des modules*, Ann. Sci. École Norm. Sup. (3) **80** (1963), 213–348.

[14] R. Schulze-Pillot, *Lecture notes on quadratic forms and their arithmetic*, arXiv:2008.12847, 2021.

[15] S. Scully, *On the holes in* I^n *for symmetric bilinear forms in characteristic* 2, arXiv:2409.02061, 2024.

[16] M. van der Put, *Espaces de Banach non archimédiens*, Bull. Soc. Math. France **97** (1969), 309–320.

[17] A. C. M. van Rooij, *Non-Archimedean Functional Analysis*, Marcel Dekker, 1978.